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It's not just games that affect children in this manner though, chatting and text messaging cause the same problems". Any system that a child interacts with can be confusing and misleading, as real-life skills are left out. Such a delusion can be very strong, with total mental dedication to something that is not true at all.

The problem arises when children confuse the real with the virtual, as Brazelina Almeida, Vice Principal of Christ Church School points out, "As was the case with WWF a while ago, children trying to emulate the fantasy world into reality can have disastrous effects. Rather they should read or go out and play". This is a problem even for adults. The sense of reward after playing a game can be so fulfilling that gamers can be misled into preferring the virtual world to the real.

Meetah Shah, another clinical psychologist and a counselor, suggests a slightly more liberal approach. She believes that in moderation a dose of gaming can be healthy on some terms (she cites the example of hand-to-eye co-ordination), but concentrating on physical activities is equally important. She suggests a timetable that allows for liberal gaming and physical activities that a parent can make a child follow. This includes not just gaming, but all kinds of entertainment-related activities such as watching movies, listening to music or spending time with friends.

We spoke to a few parents of children who were really into gaming. Two things we noticed were parents scheduled timings for studies, gaming and physical activities. Academic performance of their children was not affected because of gaming. Moreover, the children themselves preferred to engage in physical activities. The console of choice for the children was the Wii, which involves more body movement than playing with just a joystick, keyboard or gamepad.

Clearly, gaming itself is not the problem. Rather, it is the overall approach to development that needs to be highlighted. As with most gamers globally, children in India need to balance their real world activities with virtual feats.

Almeida is of the opinion that the kind of games, their content, and the time spent on them must be regulated by the parents. "I'm most concerned about latch-key kids who are left unsupervised for long periods of time. Since games are obviously entertaining, self regulation by children themselves is unlikely." Children these days are exposed to a lot of things, and there are undesirable messages everywhere.

When asked specifically about how violence in gaming affects children, Shah pointed out, "violence is everywhere, including Tom and Jerry cartoons. What is of importance is the

parents' attitude towards their children, and how well they are able to guide their children through the formative years".

Experts agree that boys are exposed to more harm from gaming than girls. This is for several reasons. Most games are designed to be played by boys. Gaming consoles are more likely to be purchased for boys rather than girls. Boys also receive more encouragement and support for using and abusing technology than girls. Most importantly, peer pressure from boys over gaming, or a particular game is much more than the necessity to be good at gaming than in girls.

But our princess is in another castle!

Since the dawn of the century, games have taken a new path. Most games released in the last five years have been centred around multiplayer gaming online. Counter Strike, one such phenomenon in India, is played across the country in schools, colleges and even offices. The dedication to developing the skills necessary to play at par with other players in the circle can be demanding and leech resources, energy and time away from other activities. Mythology, fantasy and technology have combined erratically to form massive multiplayer online role-playing games (MMORPG). These are highly intensive games, requiring endless hours of gameplay, where a virtual character develops over time depending on the choices and activities of the person who is playing. One of the most popular role playing games in India is *Ragnarok*.

Internationally, games such as *World of Warcraft* have many dedicated players. Children are more susceptible to MMORPGs because of the number of hours of gameplay required. Also, the danger of confusing the real world for the virtual world is increased because of the role playing nature of the game. These games are gender-neutral, and allow either gender to play with characters of any gender. Adults and children alike are exposed to problems with such games.

Experts, psychologists and educators agree that these games are not good for children. Left unsupervised, they can cause considerable harm to children. Specifically, the harm that is associated with gaming is a confusion of reality, exposure to violence and lethargy.

Such accusations are not new to entertainment, and have been around for a long time. All forms of entertainment have the same side effects. Movies, music and even books have all been accused with the same negative repercussions during their time. Experts agree that the key is to ensure a balance between time spent in entertainment vis-à-vis studying or development. It's always healthy to be passionate, but how far is far enough? In India, massive online multiplayer games have not spread as well as they have in other countries. Therefore, we don't experience heavy fallout from it.

The truth is that most of today's debates about gaming being good or bad for you are centred around massive online multiplayer games, the community, and how obsessed they are with playing. Is there anything wrong with a child who plays six hours at a stretch during vacations? Although we have no answer to that question, many feel that's way too far. Communities develop their own codes, in-jokes, temperaments and attitudes. Nevertheless, as it is said, anything in excess is bad.

Many gamers cannot distinguish between the real and virtual world, and often events in each affect the other. Fortunately, India is not facing such problems yet, but it's happening all over the globe. Divorces in real life due to affairs in virtual worlds or large amounts of money being paid in the real world for hard-to-find gadgets in a virtual world are almost everyday occurrences. With a picture of a virtual funeral in *World of Warcraft* for a girl who died playing it in the real world, we leave you to decide – whether there is anything horribly wrong here. (with inputs from Kumar Jhuremalani and Siddharth Parwatay) ■

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A virtual funeral in *World of Warcraft* for a real world death